



Investigation report

Rejected take-off and runway overrun, Tarlton Springs - Executive brief

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INVESTIGATION WORKFLOW SUITE

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What happened

On the evening of 18 June 2026, Saltbush Air flight SB512 was preparing to depart Tarlton Springs Aerodrome. The aircraft was a 50-seat twin-turboprop registered VH-SBQ, carrying 44 passengers, 2 flight crew and 1 cabin crew. It was the fifth sector of the flight crew's duty. That morning the evening rotation had been added to their duty when a member of the rostered crew reported unfit. The doors closed on schedule at 07:16 UTC. Tarlton Springs has no control tower, so pilots broadcast their own intentions on the CTAF. The only runway inspection that day had been carried out early that morning, before the first scheduled arrival, and it recorded the movement area as clear. No further inspection was requested by the crew or offered by the aerodrome before this departure. No wildlife was reported on the CTAF in the preceding 90 minutes. The crew switched on the runway lighting at 07:21:50 and broadcast that they were lining up on runway 09 at 07:29:10. The wind was from 090 at 6 kt. The take-off roll began at 07:30:02, with the first officer flying and both engines delivering matching power. The departure took place in darkness, about 5 minutes after last light, with no moon.

The crew called V1 at 112 kt at 07:30:29. Two seconds later, the first officer saw two kangaroos crossing the runway from the northern side to the south and called them out on the left. The estimated range at first sight was around 200 m. At 07:30:32, with the words "Stopping. I have control.", the take-off was rejected at 118 kt, 6 kt and 3 seconds past V1. The power levers reached flight idle within 0.6 seconds, with 695 m of sealed runway remaining. A second later the aircraft struck both animals with the No. 2 propeller and the right main landing gear. The strike damaged three propeller blades beyond limits and left reverse thrust on that engine unavailable for the rest of the stop. Maximum braking was established 2 seconds after the decision to stop, and anti-skid was active on all four wheels. The crew selected No. 1 reverse at 07:30:36. Even so, the aircraft slowed less than the scheduled figures for a rejected take-off. It left the sealed runway at approximately 21 kt at 07:30:51. It came to rest at 07:30:57, 62 m into the 90 m runway end safety area, upright and on the extended centreline. It stopped 28 m short of the end of the prepared area, beyond which the ground is ungraded. There was no fire. At the pilot in command's request, the aerodrome emergency plan was activated at 07:32:10 and the aerodrome was closed. Passengers left by the forward airstair in a precautionary disembarkation, without an emergency evacuation, and were clear by 07:38:48. There were no serious injuries. One cabin crew member reported bruising during the disembarkation. Both kangaroos were killed. The aircraft was substantially damaged, and the aerodrome remained closed for 4 hours 20 minutes.

Why it happened

The aircraft overran the runway because it did not slow as quickly as the published figures for a rejected take-off assume, and because the stop began after V1. Both conditions traced back to the two kangaroos on the runway.

The kangaroos' crossing onto the sealed runway was the central event. It was extremely likely to have influenced the decision to reject the take-off. It was also virtually certain to have led to the strike on the No. 2 propeller and the right main landing gear. The strike, in turn, was virtually certain to have reduced the aircraft's deceleration below the scheduled stopping performance. That reduced deceleration was virtually certain to have contributed to the overrun. The take-off was rejected 6 kt above V1, and this was extremely likely to have contributed to the overrun as well, because the stop began with less runway remaining than the scheduled figures allow for.

Several conditions explain why the animals were on the runway. The aircraft departed during the logged peak period for kangaroo activity, which runs from 1 hour before to 2 hours after last light. It is likely that this timing contributed to the crossing. The fence on the northern side of the aerodrome had failed. It was left unrepaired through three budget rounds, and it is likely that this allowed the animals onto the strip (Safety issue). The applicable standard set a threshold that left the aerodrome without a documented wildlife plan. It is likely that this was why the failed fence went unrepaired (Safety issue).

The crew did not request a runway inspection before departing after last light. It is likely that this also contributed to the animals being on the runway when the take-off began. The requirements did not prompt such a request. An inspection after last light was required only where a wildlife strike had been reported in the previous 24 months. It is very likely that this narrow requirement led to no inspection being sought (Safety issue).

Two further conditions bore on the timing of the decision to stop. The take-off roll took place in darkness, about 5 minutes after last light, with no moon. It is likely that the darkness contributed to the take-off being rejected above V1. The evening service had been approved without reopening a risk assessment that had been prepared for daylight operations only. It is likely that this approval was what placed the departure in darkness (Safety issue). The crew also had no training or guidance on how to respond to a runway obstruction during the take-off roll. It is likely that this absence contributed to the decision to reject the take-off above V1 (Safety issue).

What we found

A finding stated without a likelihood term was established as fact.

Contributing safety factors

- It is virtually certain that the standard's threshold left the aerodrome with no documented wildlife plan, and it is likely that this contributed to the overrun (Safety issue).
- The failed northern fence was left unrepaired through three budget rounds, which is virtually certain, and this likely contributed to the overrun (Safety issue).
- SB512's departure in the logged kangaroo peak, 1 h before to 2 h after last light, is very likely, and the timing likely contributed to the overrun.
- Under the operator's procedures, an inspection after last light was required only where a wildlife strike had been reported in 24 months, which is virtually certain, and this very likely contributed to the overrun (Safety issue).
- It is virtually certain that no runway inspection was requested before departing after last light, and it is likely that this contributed to the overrun.
- Two kangaroos crossed the strip onto the sealed runway, which is virtually certain, and their crossing very likely contributed to the overrun.
- It is very likely that there was no training or guidance for a runway obstruction during the take-off roll, and it is likely that this gap contributed to the overrun (Safety issue).
- The evening service was approved without reopening the daylight-only risk assessment, which is virtually certain, and this likely contributed to the overrun (Safety issue).
- SB512's roll in darkness, 5 minutes after last light, with no moon, is virtually certain, and the darkness likely contributed to the overrun.
- The take-off was rejected 6 kt above V1, which is virtually certain, and this very likely contributed to the overrun.
- On impact, the No. 2 propeller and right main gear struck two kangaroos, which is virtually certain, and the strike's contribution to the overrun is also virtually certain.
- Deceleration below the scheduled accelerate-stop performance is virtually certain, and so is its contribution to the overrun.

Other factors that increased risk

- The evening rotation was rostered to close five-sector duties within 45 minutes of the limit, which is virtually certain, and it is likely that this increased risk on the route, although it was not found to have contributed to this occurrence (Safety issue).
- Floor escape path lighting was checked only every 24 months, not pre-flight, which is virtually certain, and it is very likely that this increased risk in any future evacuation, although it played no part in this occurrence (Safety issue).

Other findings

- The investigation examined a tailwind component during the take-off roll and stop and set it aside as very unlikely, because the weather station and the aircraft data both recorded a headwind throughout.
- A No. 2 engine power loss before the reject decision was examined and found very unlikely, because the recorded loss of No. 2 power began at the moment of impact, after the reject had started.

- Maximum braking was established within 2 seconds of the reject decision, which is virtually certain, and it very likely reduced the risk by limiting how far the aircraft travelled into the runway end safety area.

What is being done

The standard's threshold left Tarlton Springs Aerodrome without a documented wildlife plan. The aerodrome was not in breach, because its traffic fell below both limbs of AS-139 10.4.2. [NOT ESTABLISHED: any action taken or proposed by the standard's owner or the aerodrome operator]

The northern fence, described in works register items WR-221 and WR-263, was still in its failed state at the site visit on 23/06/2026. No repair, funding decision or other action has been recorded. [NOT ESTABLISHED: any action by Tarlton Shire Council or the aerodrome operator, and its status]

The evening service had been approved under CMR-2025-118 without reopening RRA-041. On 19/06/2026 the Head of Flying Operations suspended it. No review of RRA-041 or of the change management process has been recorded. [NOT ESTABLISHED: the current status of the suspension and any review proposed]

Under the operator's procedures, an aerodrome could be listed in Appendix 8A, which requires a runway inspection after last light, only after a wildlife strike was reported there. The investigation raised this with the operator's Safety Department on 02/07/2026. [NOT ESTABLISHED: the Safety Department's response and any action taken]

Neither recurrent training module TRG-SYL-07 module 4 nor Operations Manual Part B 4.6 addressed a runway obstruction during the take-off roll. [NOT ESTABLISHED: any change proposed to training or procedures]

The evening rotation was rostered to close five-sector duties within 45 minutes of the limit. The suspension covers this rotation, but no change to the roster pattern has been recorded. [NOT ESTABLISHED: any action on the roster]

On this type, floor escape path lighting is checked only by a functional test every 24 months. Engineering is still establishing whether the failed ballast part is common across the fleet, and how many aircraft are inside the test interval. No change to the test interval or the pre-flight test has been recorded.

Distribution

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Figures



Figure 1: The northern perimeter fence at the 1,050 m mark, photographed on the site visit: the fallen section and the animal pad through it. Site inspection photograph SV-2026-0417-07, northern boundary at the 1,050 m runway marker, taken 23/06/2026